And they stretched their cord of vision across the void,
What was above? What was below?
Then seeds were sown and mighty power arose,
Below was strength, Above was impulse.

Who really knows? And who can say?
Whence did it all come? And how did creation happen?
The gods themselves are later than creation,
So who knows truly whence this great creation sprang?

Who knows whence this creation had its origin?
He, whether He fashioned it or whether He did not,
He, who surveys it all from the highest heaven,
He knows—or maybe even He does not know.

— *Rig Veda*, X.129[1]

'Maybe even He does not know!' I love a faith that raises such a fundamental question about no less a Supreme Being than the Creator of the Universe Himself. Maybe He does not know, indeed. Who are we mere mortals to claim a knowledge of which even He cannot be certain?

Hindu thought also makes a virtue out of the unknowability of God. There is a marvellous story in the Upanishads about a sage who is asked to define the nature of God; the wise man, normally loquacious, falls silent. He is pressed by his disciples for an answer, and he replies that that *was* his answer, for the Absolute is silence; the mystery of the divine reality cannot be reduced to words or speech. Neither thought nor words can suffice: 'It is not understood by those who understand it,' says the Kena Upanishad, 'it is understood by those who do not understand it.' The final words of the Upanishads are '*neti*, *neti*'—'not this, not this'—signifying the indescribability of the Absolute. For many sages, their consciousness of the Divine is untranslatable to others, for those who have not attained the same realisation cannot grasp it through word or sign: it is 'that of which nothing can be said'.

And while I am, paradoxically, listing my 'reasons' for a faith beyond understanding, let me cite the fundamental point: above all, as a Hindu I belong to the only major religion in the world that does not claim to be the only true religion. I find it immensely congenial to be able to face my fellow human beings of other faiths without being burdened by the conviction that I am embarked upon a 'true path' that they have missed.